

THAILAND REAL ESTATE TERMINOLOGY & REGIONAL GUIDE

Complete Reference for Phuket Region

2025 Edition

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PART I: PROPERTY TERMINOLOGY

1. LAND TITLES & DOCUMENTS

Chanote (Nor Sor 4 Jor)

The highest and most secure form of land title in Thailand. Issued by Land Office with GPS coordinates. Provides absolute proof of ownership with precisely surveyed boundaries. Can be sold, transferred, mortgaged without restrictions. This is the 'gold standard' for property purchases.

Nor Sor 3 Gor

Certificate of Use. Second-best title document. Land boundaries surveyed but not with GPS precision. Can be upgraded to Chanote. Acceptable for most property transactions but less secure than Chanote.

Nor Sor 3

Certificate of Notification of Use. Land possession document with approximate boundaries. Less secure, harder to upgrade to Chanote. Not recommended for foreign purchases.

Sor Kor 1

Claim Receipt. Lowest level of land documentation. Merely acknowledges land claim. Cannot be sold or transferred. Not suitable for property investment.

FET Form

Foreign Exchange Transaction Form. Issued by Thai banks for international transfers exceeding USD 50,000. Essential document for foreigners buying freehold condominiums. Must be presented at Land Office.

Tabien Baan

House Registration Book. Lists residents at a property address. Blue book for Thai nationals, Yellow book for registered foreigners. Not proof of ownership, only residence registration.

Deed of Sale

Official transfer document registered at Land Office. Proves transfer of ownership. Contains property details, buyer/seller information, price, and official stamps.

2. PROPERTY TYPES

Condominium (Condo)

Multi-unit residential building registered under Condominium Act. Offers individual unit ownership with title deed. Includes shared ownership of common areas (land, building exterior, facilities). Foreigners can own units freehold within 49% quota.

Apartment

Multi-unit building NOT registered as condominium. Does NOT offer individual unit ownership. Residents have only contractual rights (lease/rental). Cannot be owned freehold by anyone. Important: Visually identical to condos but legally very different.

Villa

Detached house, typically with private pool and garden. Can be purchased on leasehold land or through Thai company. Building can be foreign-owned, but land cannot.

Townhouse

Attached house sharing walls with neighboring units. Usually 2-3 stories with small garden. Same ownership restrictions as villas - land must be leased or company-owned.

Landed Property

General term for properties with land (houses, villas, townhouses). Foreigners cannot own land directly, must use leasehold or company structure.

Serviced Apartment

Apartment with hotel-like services (cleaning, reception, facilities management). Can be condos (with ownership) or apartments (without ownership). Check carefully.

Resort Villa

Villa within managed resort complex. Often includes rental pool program. Professional management, shared facilities, but may have usage restrictions.

Off-Plan Property

Property purchased before construction completion. Lower prices, payment plans, but carries completion risk. Requires careful due diligence on developer.

3. OWNERSHIP TERMS

Freehold

Absolute ownership without time limitation. Owner has complete rights forever. For foreigners: only condominium units within quota. Higher price but maximum security.

Leasehold

Long-term rental right for specified period. Standard: 30 years renewable. Must be registered for terms >3 years. Lower cost than freehold. Renewal not guaranteed.

Usufruct

Lifetime right to use property and receive income from it. Cannot be sold. Ends at death. Maximum 30 years if registered, can be renewed. Similar to leasehold but emphasizes usage rights.

Superficies

Right to own buildings on someone else's land. Up to 30 years, renewable once. Building owner different from land owner. Can mortgage building separately from land.

Sap-Ing-Sitthi (Habitation Right)

Right to occupy property. Less common than usufruct. Cannot sublease. Maximum 30 years. Government considering extension to 99 years.

Foreign Quota

The 49% of condominium floor area that can be sold to foreigners. Remaining 51% must be Thai-owned. Calculated by area, not unit count.

Thai Quota

The 51% of condominium that must be owned by Thai nationals. Foreigners can purchase from Thai quota only through Thai company structure.

Nominee

Thai shareholders in company formed to hold property for foreigner. ILLEGAL if shareholders are not genuine investors. Heavily scrutinized since 2025.

4. FINANCIAL TERMS

Transfer Fee

2% of assessed value (freehold) or 1% (leasehold). Paid when registering ownership. Usually split 50/50 between buyer and seller, but negotiable. Developer can charge buyer maximum 50% for new properties.

Sinking Fund

One-time contribution for major repairs/replacements. Typically THB 500-1,000 per sqm. Paid at purchase. Managed by condominium juristic person.

Common Area Maintenance (CAM) Fee

Monthly/annual fee for building management, security, facilities, utilities. Usually THB 30-80 per sqm per month depending on building standards. Paid to juristic person.

Management Fee

For serviced properties or rental pools. Typically 20-40% of rental income. Covers marketing, guest services, maintenance, administration.

Assessed Value

Government-appraised value for tax purposes. Usually lower than market value. Used to calculate transfer fee, stamp duty, withholding tax. Different from contract price.

Rental Yield

Annual rental income as percentage of property value. Formula: $(\text{Annual Rent} / \text{Property Value}) \times 100$. Phuket average: 4-8% for condos, 5-10% for villas.

Gross Yield

Rental yield before expenses. $\text{Total rental income} / \text{Purchase price}$.

Net Yield

Rental yield after all expenses (fees, taxes, maintenance, vacancy). More accurate measure of investment return.

Down Payment

Initial payment when reserving property. Typically 20-30% for completed properties, 10-30% for off-plan. Held in escrow or developer account.

Installment Plan

Payment schedule for off-plan properties. Common structure: 10% down, quarterly payments during construction, 70% at completion.

PART II: MEASUREMENTS & CALCULATIONS

7. THAI LAND MEASUREMENTS

Thailand uses traditional land measurement units alongside metric system:

Thai Unit	Metric Equivalent	Notes
1 Wah (Wa)	2 meters	Basic unit, approximately 4 steps
1 Tarang Wah (Sq Wah)	4 square meters	Square wah, for small plots
1 Ngan	100 Tarang Wah = 400 sqm	Quarter of a rai
1 Rai	4 Ngan = 1,600 sqm	Standard land measurement unit
1 Rai	0.16 hectares	International conversion
1 Rai	0.395 acres	US/UK conversion

Common Conversions:

- 100 sqm = 25 Tarang Wah
- 200 sqm = 50 Tarang Wah = 0.5 Ngan
- 400 sqm = 1 Ngan
- 800 sqm = 2 Ngan = 0.5 Rai
- 1,600 sqm = 1 Rai

Practical Example: A land plot described as '2 Rai 1 Ngan 50 Sq Wah' equals: $(2 \times 1,600) + (1 \times 400) + (50 \times 4) = 3,200 + 400 + 200 = 3,800$ square meters.

PART III: PHUKET REGIONAL GUIDE

10. OVERVIEW OF PHUKET

Phuket, known as the 'Pearl of the Andaman', is Thailand's largest island and most popular international tourist destination. Located in southern Thailand, it has evolved from a traditional fishing and tin-mining island into a sophisticated resort destination with world-class infrastructure.

Key Facts:

- Area: 576 square kilometers
- Population: Approximately 450,000 residents
- Annual tourists: 10+ million visitors
- Beaches: 30+ beaches around the island
- Climate: Tropical monsoon (hot and humid year-round)
- High season: November to April (dry season)
- Low season: May to October (rainy season)

Why Phuket for Real Estate:

- Strong rental demand from tourism
- International airport with direct flights worldwide
- Modern infrastructure (hospitals, schools, shopping)
- Large expat community and support services
- Year-round warm weather
- Diverse property options at various price points
- Strong property appreciation history
- Well-established legal framework for foreign ownership

11. PHUKET DISTRICTS & AREAS

11.1 West Coast (Premium Beach Areas)

Bang Tao: 8km beach, upscale area. Home to Laguna Phuket complex. Premium developments, golf courses, international schools. Family-friendly. Beach clubs, fine dining. Price: High. Rental yield: 5-7%. Best for: Luxury investment, family living.

Surin: Sophisticated beach area. Exclusive villas, boutique hotels. Wealthy Thai and international residents. Beach clubs, upscale dining. Quieter than Patong. Price: Very High. Rental yield: 4-6%. Best for: High-end investment.

Kamala: Family beach resort area. Mix of budget and luxury. More relaxed than Patong. Growing development. Good restaurants, beach clubs. Price: Medium-High. Rental yield: 6-8%. Best for: Balanced investment.

Patong: Most famous, busiest area. Entertainment capital. Bangla Road nightlife. High tourist traffic. Dense development. Shopping centers. Price: Medium-High. Rental yield: 6-9%. Best for: Rental income.

Kata & Karon: Twin beach areas. Popular with families and surfers. Good mix of properties. Established infrastructure. Less hectic than Patong. Price: Medium. Rental yield: 6-8%. Best for: Steady rentals.

11.2 South Phuket (Value & Lifestyle)

Rawai: Bohemian beach area. Large expat community. Waterfront seafood. More authentic Thai feel. Good value. Growing development. Price: Medium-Low. Rental yield: 7-9%. Best for: Lifestyle, value investment.

Nai Harn: Beautiful beach, exclusive feel. Mix of luxury and mid-range. Scenic viewpoints. Less commercialized. Quality restaurants. Price: Medium-High. Rental yield: 5-7%. Best for: Quality lifestyle.

Chalong: Central location. Yacht haven. Mix of residential and commercial. Major pier for island tours. Hospital, shopping. Not beachfront. Price: Medium. Rental yield: 6-8%. Best for: Central location value.

13. MARKET PRICING BY AREA (2025)

The following table provides approximate price ranges for different property types across Phuket's main areas. Prices in Thai Baht per square meter.

Area	Condo (THB/sqm)	Villa (THB/sqm)	Notes
Bang Tao	120,000-250,000	180,000-400,000	Premium, Laguna area
Surin	150,000-300,000	200,000-500,000	Most expensive
Kamala	90,000-180,000	120,000-250,000	Good balance
Patong	80,000-200,000	150,000-300,000	High density
Kata/Karon	70,000-150,000	100,000-200,000	Established area
Rawai	60,000-120,000	80,000-150,000	Best value
Nai Harn	90,000-180,000	120,000-250,000	Quality area
Chalong	50,000-100,000	70,000-150,000	Non-beachfront

Price Factors: Sea view adds 30-50%, beachfront adds 50-100%, brand name developers add 20-40%, facilities quality, floor level, unit size, and building age all affect pricing.

PART IV: PRACTICAL INFORMATION

15. COMMON ABBREVIATIONS

sqm: Square meters

BA: Bathroom

CAM: Common Area Maintenance

FET: Foreign Exchange Transaction

LTR: Long-Term Resident (visa)

Condo: Condominium

PF: Partially Furnished

ROI: Return on Investment

SPA: Sale and Purchase Agreement

EIA: Environmental Impact Assessment

BR or B/R: Bedroom

BUA: Built-Up Area

THB: Thai Baht (currency)

BOI: Board of Investment

DTV: Digital Nomad Visa

FF: Fully Furnished

UF: Unfurnished

HOA: Homeowners Association

POA: Power of Attorney

CBD: Central Business District

18. COST OF LIVING IN PHUKET (2025)

Monthly living costs for expatriates in Phuket vary significantly based on lifestyle. Below are approximate monthly expenses in Thai Baht:

Category	Budget	Moderate	Comfortable	Luxury
Rent (1BR)	15,000	25,000	40,000	70,000+
Utilities	2,000	3,500	5,000	8,000
Food & Dining	10,000	20,000	35,000	60,000
Transportation	3,000	6,000	10,000	20,000
Insurance	3,000	5,000	8,000	15,000
Entertainment	5,000	10,000	20,000	40,000
Internet/Phone	1,500	2,000	2,500	3,000
TOTAL/MONTH	39,500	71,500	120,500	216,000+
USD Equivalent*	\$1,130	\$2,040	\$3,440	\$6,170

* Based on exchange rate: 1 USD = 35 THB

Additional Notes:

- Healthcare: International hospital treatment 50-70% cheaper than Western countries
- Education: International school fees THB 400,000-800,000/year
- Car: Toyota Fortuner approximately THB 1,500,000
- Scooter rental: THB 3,000-5,000/month
- Gym membership: THB 1,500-3,000/month
- Housekeeping: THB 8,000-15,000/month

DISCLAIMER

This guide provides general information for reference purposes only. Property markets and living costs fluctuate. Always verify current information and consult qualified professionals. The publisher assumes no liability for decisions made based on this information.

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